

# Factors Affecting Career Planning

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Choosing a career is one of the most important decisions a young person will make. It affects income, lifestyle, identity, relationships, and long-term fulfillment. Yet many students make career choices based on incomplete information, pressure from others, or momentary trends. A well-made career decision considers three broad categories of factors: personal factors (who you are), social factors (who influences you), and environmental factors (what the world offers and demands). Ignoring any of these categories leads to poor fit, regret, or wasted effort. Understanding how these factors interact allows students to make informed, realistic, and personally meaningful career plans.

This reading material discusses the importance of considering personal, social, and environmental factors in career planning. It explains how skills, interests, and talents shape career direction. It describes academic and skills requirements for different careers. It examines influences such as economic considerations, parental decisions, and in-demand careers. Finally, it explains opportunities such as scholarships and employment prospects.

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## Part 1: Why Personal, Social, and Environmental Factors Matter

Career planning is not simply choosing a job. It is matching who you are with what the world needs and offers. Three categories of factors must be considered together.

| Factor Category | What It Includes                                                             | Why It Matters                                       |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Personal        | Skills, interests, talents, values, personality, health, financial situation | Determines satisfaction, motivation, and performance |

| Factor Category | What It Includes                                                                            | Why It Matters                                        |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Social          | Family expectations, peer influence, cultural norms, mentors, teachers                      | Shapes opportunities, support, and pressure           |
| Environmental   | Economic conditions, labor market demand, technology trends, government policies, geography | Determines availability of jobs, salaries, and growth |

## Why All Three Must Be Considered

| If You Ignore...      | Possible Consequence                                                |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Personal factors      | You may choose a career you dislike or cannot perform well          |
| Social factors        | You may face conflict, lack support, or follow someone else's dream |
| Environmental factors | You may train for a job that no longer exists or pays too little    |

**Key insight:** A career decision that considers only one category is incomplete. The best decisions balance all three.

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## Part 2: Skills, Interests, and Talents

### Defining the Three

| Element | Definition                               | Example                                              |
|---------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Skill   | A learned ability to perform a task well | Writing clearly, coding, cooking, repairing machines |

| Element  | Definition                                             | Example                                               |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Interest | Something you enjoy doing or learning about            | Reading, sports, music, helping others                |
| Talent   | A natural aptitude or quick ability to learn something | Musical ear, spatial reasoning, athletic coordination |

**Key distinction:** Skills can be developed through practice. Talents are innate but still require development. Interests may change over time.

## Why Self-Awareness Matters

| Reason      | Explanation                                                   |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fit         | Careers aligned with skills and interests are more satisfying |
| Motivation  | Doing what you enjoy sustains effort through challenges       |
| Performance | Natural talents give a head start in some fields              |
| Growth      | Knowing your gaps helps you plan training                     |

## Self-Assessment Questions

| Area      | Questions to Ask                                                       |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Skills    | What am I good at? What do others ask me to help with?                 |
| Interests | What do I enjoy doing in my free time? What topics absorb me?          |
| Talents   | What comes easily to me? What do I learn faster than others?           |
| Values    | What matters most to me (security, creativity, service, independence)? |

| Area        | Questions to Ask                                                 |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Personality | Am I outgoing or reserved? Do I prefer structure or flexibility? |

## Matching Personal Factors to Career Clusters

| Personal Strength    | Possible Career Clusters                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Strong communication | Teaching, law, media, public relations, counseling            |
| Analytical thinking  | Engineering, data science, accounting, research               |
| Creativity           | Design, arts, advertising, architecture, film                 |
| Helping orientation  | Medicine, nursing, social work, psychology                    |
| Technical/mechanical | Information technology, automotive, electronics, construction |
| Leadership           | Management, entrepreneurship, politics, military              |

## Skills Beyond Technical Ability

Employers increasingly value **transferable skills** that apply across careers.

| Transferable Skill | Why It Matters                        |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Communication      | Needed in every job                   |
| Teamwork           | Most work is collaborative            |
| Problem-solving    | Employers value workers who can think |
| Time management    | Deadlines are universal               |

| Transferable Skill | Why It Matters                           |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Digital literacy   | Technology is part of nearly every field |
| Adaptability       | Careers and industries change rapidly    |

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## Part 3: Academic and Skills Requirements

### Why Requirements Matter

Every career has entry requirements. Some require specific degrees, licenses, or certifications. Others value experience, portfolios, or demonstrated skills. Knowing these requirements early allows students to plan their senior high school track, college course, and training path.

### Types of Requirements

| Requirement Type     | Description                                   | Example                                    |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Academic degree      | Formal education from a college or university | Bachelor of Science in Nursing for nursing |
| Licensure            | Government examination required to practice   | Licensure Examination for Teachers (LET)   |
| Certification        | Industry-recognized credential                | TESDA NC II in Cookery                     |
| Portfolio            | Collection of work samples                    | Graphic design portfolio                   |
| Experience           | Prior work or internship                      | Apprenticeship for skilled trades          |
| Specialized training | Short courses or workshops                    | First aid, coding bootcamp                 |

## Matching Senior High School Tracks to Career Paths

| SHS Track             | Possible Career Directions                             |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Academic – STEM       | Engineering, medicine, data science, architecture      |
| Academic – ABM        | Business, accounting, entrepreneurship, management     |
| Academic – HUMSS      | Law, teaching, journalism, psychology, politics        |
| Academic – GAS        | Flexible path; can lead to many college courses        |
| TVL – ICT             | Software development, technical support, animation     |
| TVL – Home Economics  | Culinary arts, hospitality, beauty care, tourism       |
| TVL – Industrial Arts | Automotive, electronics, welding, construction         |
| Sports                | Coaching, fitness, sports science, physical therapy    |
| Arts and Design       | Visual arts, performing arts, design, creative writing |

## Academic Requirements for Common Careers

| Career     | Typical Degree        | Additional Requirements            |
|------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------|
| Doctor     | Doctor of Medicine    | Pre-med degree, medical board exam |
| Lawyer     | Bachelor of Laws      | Pre-law degree, bar exam           |
| Engineer   | BS Engineering        | Licensure exam                     |
| Teacher    | Bachelor of Education | LET                                |
| Accountant | BS Accountancy        | CPA board exam                     |

| Career      | Typical Degree                       | Additional Requirements   |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| Nurse       | BS Nursing                           | Nurse licensure exam      |
| Chef        | Culinary arts or TESDA certification | Experience, portfolio     |
| Programmer  | BS Computer Science or IT            | Portfolio, certifications |
| Electrician | TESDA NC II                          | Licensure, experience     |

## Planning for Requirements

| Step | Action                                                     |
|------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Identify your target career                                |
| 2    | Research its requirements (degree, license, certification) |
| 3    | Determine which SHS track aligns with those requirements   |
| 4    | Identify colleges or training centers offering the program |
| 5    | Plan finances and timelines                                |
| 6    | Build relevant skills and experience early                 |

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## Part 4: Influences on Career Choice

Career decisions are rarely made in isolation. Many forces shape what students consider possible or desirable.

## Economic Considerations

| Factor              | How It Influences Career Choice                         |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Family income       | Limits or expands options for education and training    |
| Cost of education   | Affects whether a student can pursue expensive programs |
| Salary expectations | Draws students toward higher-paying fields              |
| Job security        | Encourages careers with stable employment               |
| Economic conditions | Recessions reduce available jobs; growth creates demand |

## Parental Influence

| Type of Influence     | Description                                        | Effect                              |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Guidance              | Parents suggest options based on experience        | Can be helpful and grounding        |
| Pressure              | Parents insist on a specific career                | Can cause resentment or poor fit    |
| Financial support     | Parents fund education only for chosen fields      | Limits or enables options           |
| Role modeling         | Parents' own careers inspire or discourage         | Shapes aspirations                  |
| Cultural expectations | Family or community norms about acceptable careers | Can conflict with personal interest |

**Healthy approach:** Listen to parents, ask questions, and explain your reasoning. In many Filipino families, career decisions involve the whole family, so respectful dialogue matters.

## In-Demand Careers

| Trend                           | In-Demand Fields                                    |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Digital transformation          | IT, data science, cybersecurity, AI                 |
| Healthcare                      | Nursing, medical technology, caregiving             |
| Renewable energy                | Solar, wind, environmental engineering              |
| Construction and infrastructure | Civil engineering, skilled trades                   |
| Education                       | Teaching, special education, educational technology |
| Business process outsourcing    | Customer service, technical support, analytics      |
| Creative industries             | Design, animation, content creation                 |

**Caution:** In-demand careers today may change. Choose a field that also matches your personal factors.

## Other Influences

| Influence              | Description                                          |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Peer influence         | Friends' choices can sway decisions                  |
| Teachers and mentors   | Guidance and encouragement shape confidence          |
| Media and social media | Portray certain careers as prestigious or glamorous  |
| Role models            | Public figures and professionals inspire aspirations |

| Influence           | Description                                         |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Cultural norms      | Gender expectations may limit or expand options     |
| Geographic location | Urban vs. rural areas offer different opportunities |

## Balancing Influences

| Healthy Decision-Making                  | Unhealthy Decision-Making          |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Considers multiple perspectives          | Follows one voice without question |
| Weighs personal fit                      | Chooses based on prestige alone    |
| Asks questions and seeks information     | Relies on assumptions              |
| Accepts guidance without losing autonomy | Gives up personal agency           |

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## Part 5: Opportunities in Career Planning

Opportunities expand what is possible. Knowing what is available — and how to access it — makes career planning more realistic.

### Types of Opportunities

| Type         | Description                             | Example                       |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Scholarships | Financial aid for education             | DOST-SEI, CHED, SM Foundation |
| Grants       | Funds for specific programs or research | Government and NGO grants     |

| Type                | Description                         | Example                           |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Internships         | Short-term work experience          | On-the-job training in companies  |
| Apprenticeships     | Paid training in skilled trades     | TESDA apprenticeship programs     |
| Part-time work      | Employment while studying           | Tutoring, retail, food service    |
| Online courses      | Flexible skill development          | Coursera, TESDA online programs   |
| Competitions        | Prizes, recognition, and networking | Skills Olympics, hackathons       |
| Government programs | Training and employment initiatives | DOLE programs, TESDA scholarships |

## Scholarships in the Philippines

| Scholarship        | Provider                                             | Coverage                                     |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| DOST-SEI           | Department of Science and Technology                 | Priority science and engineering courses     |
| CHED Scholarships  | Commission on Higher Education                       | Various programs; merit and need-based       |
| TESDA Scholarships | Technical Education and Skills Development Authority | Skills training and certifications           |
| SM Foundation      | Private foundation                                   | College scholarships for low-income students |
| Ayala Foundation   | Private foundation                                   | Scholarships and leadership programs         |

| Scholarship                   | Provider                      | Coverage                                        |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Local government scholarships | City or municipal governments | Varies by locality                              |
| University merit scholarships | Colleges and universities     | Tuition discounts based on academic performance |

## Employment Opportunities

| Source                | How It Helps                                   |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Job portals           | Online listings of available positions         |
| Government job fairs  | Direct contact with employers                  |
| School career centers | Guidance, referrals, and workshops             |
| Alumni networks       | Connections to professionals in various fields |
| Internships           | Pathways to full-time employment               |
| Freelancing platforms | Flexible work for skilled individuals          |

## How to Access Opportunities

| Step | Action                                    |
|------|-------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Research available programs and deadlines |
| 2    | Prepare required documents early          |
| 3    | Meet with guidance counselors and mentors |

| Step | Action                                       |
|------|----------------------------------------------|
| 4    | Apply to multiple opportunities              |
| 5    | Build a portfolio of skills and achievements |
| 6    | Network with professionals and alumni        |
| 7    | Follow up on applications                    |

## Barriers to Opportunities

| Barrier               | Possible Response                                            |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Financial limitations | Apply for scholarships; consider TESDA or state universities |
| Lack of information   | Consult guidance counselors; search reliable websites        |
| Geographic distance   | Consider online programs or relocation                       |
| Family obligations    | Discuss options with family; explore flexible schedules      |
| Low confidence        | Seek mentorship; build small wins                            |

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## Part 6: Putting It All Together – A Career Planning Framework

### The Four-Step Decision Process

| Step | Action        | Guiding Questions                                   |
|------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Know yourself | What are my skills, interests, talents, and values? |

| Step | Action                 | Guiding Questions                                                        |
|------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2    | Know the requirements  | What education, training, and licenses are needed?                       |
| 3    | Know the influences    | Who and what are shaping my decision? Are they helping or pressuring me? |
| 4    | Know the opportunities | What scholarships, programs, and jobs are available?                     |

## A Personal Career Planning Template

| Category | My Response |
|----------|-------------|
|----------|-------------|

Skills

Interests

Talents

Values

Preferred SHS track

Target career

Academic requirements

Licenses or certifications needed

Influences I should consider

Influences I should resist

Category

My Response

Scholarships to apply for

Backup career options

## Common Mistakes in Career Planning

| Mistake                           | Why It Fails                                     | Better Approach                                        |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Choosing only by salary           | Money alone does not sustain motivation          | Balance salary with interest and skill                 |
| Following a friend's choice       | Their fit is not your fit                        | Make your own informed decision                        |
| Ignoring requirements             | Training takes years; late discovery wastes time | Research requirements early                            |
| Chasing trends                    | Trends change; demand shifts                     | Choose careers with lasting relevance and personal fit |
| Giving in to pressure             | Resentment and poor performance follow           | Discuss openly; seek compromise where possible         |
| Refusing to consider alternatives | Rigid plans break when conditions change         | Prepare backup options                                 |

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## Key Terms

| Term                | Definition                                                                                  |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Career planning     | The process of matching personal attributes with educational and occupational opportunities |
| Skill               | A learned ability to perform a task                                                         |
| Interest            | Something a person enjoys doing or learning                                                 |
| Talent              | A natural aptitude or quick ability to learn                                                |
| Transferable skills | Abilities useful across many careers                                                        |
| Licensure           | Government examination required to practice a profession                                    |
| Certification       | Industry-recognized credential                                                              |
| Portfolio           | Collection of work samples demonstrating ability                                            |
| Scholarship         | Financial aid for education                                                                 |
| Apprenticeship      | Paid training in a skilled trade                                                            |
| In-demand career    | A field with high current demand for workers                                                |
| Career cluster      | A group of careers sharing common skills and interests                                      |

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## Review Questions

1. Explain why personal, social, and environmental factors should all be considered in career planning. Provide one consequence of ignoring each.
2. Differentiate skills, interests, and talents. Provide one example of each.
3. List five self-assessment questions that help identify personal factors for career planning.
4. Identify four types of requirements for careers and give one example of each.
5. Explain how parental influence can be both helpful and harmful in career planning.
6. Describe two economic considerations that affect career choice.
7. List three scholarships available in the Philippines and explain what each covers.
8. Study the scenario below and answer the questions that follow.

A Grade 11 student excels in mathematics and enjoys solving problems. The student's parents want him to take up Nursing because it is in demand abroad. However, the student is more interested in Engineering. The family has limited income, and the student is worried about tuition costs.

- (a) Identify the personal, social, and environmental factors at play.
  - (b) How can the student balance parental expectations with personal interests?
  - (c) What opportunities could help address the financial concern?
9. Explain why choosing a career based only on "in-demand" lists can be risky.
  10. Application question: Using the four-step career planning framework (know yourself, know the requirements, know the influences, know the opportunities), create a brief career plan for yourself. Include at least three personal factors, two requirements, two influences, and two opportunities.